

Health restored, young bald eagle flies into the wild

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VAN WYCK, S.C. — It was the perfect ending to a patriotic weekend.

More than 150 people gathered in a pasture on Nisbet Farm, north of Lancaster, Sunday morning to witness the essence of American spirit: the release of a young bald eagle.

Nursed back to health after a gunshot broke its left wing four months ago, the 1½-year-old eagle flew to freedom, drifting over a line of trees, never looking back.

The crowd cheered as the eagle disappeared into the distance. The applause was also a tribute to the success of the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville.

In early March, the Raptor Center got a call about a large, wounded bird found behind a home in western York.

Ron Clark, a Charlotte woodworker who has volunteered at the center for more than five years, captured the fallen eagle and brought it back to the rehabilitation center. He was thrilled to take part in the release.

"People always ask me if I'm sad to let them go," he said. "For me it's a good feeling. It's always a pleasure to see them return to where they belong."

When Clark removed the eagle from its cage Sunday, the bird looked into the eager crowd's waiting cameras. As it was carried out into a field to be released, the young eagle flapped its soft, fluffy mass of brown wings and called out, poised for flight.

Clark then handed the eagle to Sgt. Sandy Young of the S.C. Wildlife and Marine Resources Department, who lifted the bird to freedom. Young is investigating the bird's shooting in conjunction with the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service in Columbia.

"This is an open investigation and we hope that people in York can help us find out who's responsible for this," Young said.

The eagle was fortunate to heal so easily, said Mathias Engelmann,

rehabilitation coordinator for the Raptor Center.

"He progressed as quickly as a bird can. Not every bird can be released, so it's exciting when we reach that goal," said Engelmann.

Although the release took less than five minutes, the crowd wasn't disappointed.

"It's an emotional experience," said Tony Bryant, a sales representative from Charlotte. "The act of freeing the bird can also be a personal release. It just felt right to me."

WANT TO HELP?

The shooting of a bald eagle breaks state and federal laws, and has a maximum penalty of a \$100,000 fine and one year in jail, according to George Hines, special agent for the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service of Columbia. If you have any information on the shooting of this or any other protected species, call 1-800-922-5431. A reward will be given for information leading to arrest.